

CRITICAL REVIEW DEVIL'S ADVOCATE STRATEGY

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Overview



The Devil's Advocate: A Strategy to Avoid Groupthink and Stimulate Discussion in Focus Groups

Colin MacDougall, Frances Baum

This study describes the results of using the Devil's Advocate strategy in focus groups.

Definitions

- **Groupthink:** Occurs when team members make uniform decisions, possibly due to fear of standing out
- **Devil's Advocate:** A person in a group who raises unique concerns, with the goal of reducing groupthink

Authors



Colin MacDougall

- Department of Public Health at Flinders University of South Australia
- Doctorate



Frances Baum

- Department of Public Health at Flinders University of South Australia
- South Australian Community Health Research Unit
- PhD
- Multiple awards

Argument

According to the authors, the Devil's Advocate strategy is:

- Generally a useful tool to prevent groupthink
- Should be implemented along with proper training
- Should not be forced into every project

“ Our use of the devil's advocate suggests that they can contribute to opening up discussion in groups and avoid a convergence of views by allowing members to feel free to express divergent opinions

Supporting the Argument



Interview Questions

Participants in the focus group were interviewed after the study was performed. Some interview responses were cited in the article.

“ [The Devil's Advocate strategy] was useful, I remember at least one occasion when the devil's advocate put another viewpoint that I hadn't considered. Opens up your mind a bit

Focus Group Participant

Persuasiveness

The article is somewhat persuasive:

- Contains low bias
- Cites interview responses directly, allowing audience to draw their own conclusions
 - Not all responses are included, so the included responses may be cherry-picked

The article fulfills its goals:

- Communicates a conclusion about the effectiveness of the Devil's Advocate strategy

“ Face-to-face training including a trial focus group would deal with many of [the participant's] criticisms

Shortcomings

- **Full interview responses not included:**
Only a few interview responses were cited throughout the article. The full raw interview transcripts would be useful to have, to get a sense of the proportion of positive to negative responses
- **Failure to support claim about suggested training:**
The article suggests that training in a trial focus group would solve many of the criticisms mentioned, but this training was never performed

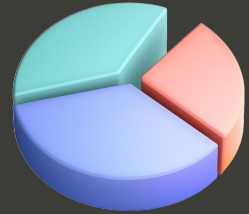
Missing Components

- **Numerical data:**

The article only used interview questions to support its argument, but no numerical data was included. The authors could have counted the number of positive and negative interview responses to get a sense of the effectiveness of the strategy

- **Control Group:**

There is no control group, all of the focus groups were treated in the same general way. It could be argued that the initial state of each group was considered a control, however, there could have been a stronger system for finding and interviewing control groups



Works Cited

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